PROJECT SCHOLARX

AI RESEARCH PROMPT LIBRARY

70 prompts with human decision gates

PROMPT LIBRARY

AI can make you faster.
Only you can make your research meaningful.

Project ScholarX • Sprint 4 Companion Resources

akhil2453.github.io/akhil-portfolio



Prompting Principles for Doctoral Researchers

These prompts are designed to support thinking, not outsource scholarship. Replace bracketed text, add your actual context, and require the model to identify uncertainty. Never ask a generative system to invent evidence or citations. Verify all source-dependent outputs in legitimate scholarly databases and original publications.

AKHIL TIP #3 The quality of a prompt matters. The quality of your judgement matters more.

Prompt component	Minimum information
Context	Industry, function, geography, population, organisational setting and current stage.
Task	The exact operation: explore, compare, critique, classify, explain, structure or test.
Constraints	No invented sources; confidentiality limits; scope; output length; assumptions to flag.
Output	Table, ranked options, question set, matrix, code with comments or critique report.
Verification	Ask the AI to distinguish evidence, inference, assumption and uncertainty.

A

Problem Framing

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

01 Clarification interview

Use when: The problem is still expressed as a complaint.

> Act as a doctoral research coach. Before suggesting a topic, ask me up to ten focused questions about this professional problem: [problem]. Cover recurrence, consequences, stakeholders, current responses, evidence access, context, assumptions and boundaries. Do not propose a title until I answer.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Answer from experience, then verify organisational claims.

02 Problem decomposition

Use when: You need to see the parts of a complex problem.

> Decompose [problem] into observable symptoms, possible mechanisms, contextual conditions, stakeholder behaviours, decisions and outcomes. Present a table and clearly label all items as hypotheses rather than facts.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Reject mechanisms that lack plausibility or access.

03 Competing explanations

Use when: Your organisation has settled too quickly on one explanation.

> Generate six competing explanations for [problem] in [context]. For each, state what evidence would support it, what evidence would weaken it, and what stakeholder perspective it represents. Do not select a winner.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Determine which explanations deserve investigation.

04 Symptom versus underlying problem

Use when: The problem statement feels vague or causal.

> Evaluate whether this statement describes a symptom, a cause, an outcome or a researchable problem: [statement]. Explain the ambiguity and propose three more precise problem statements.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Choose wording that does not assume causality.

05 Stakeholder map

Use when: Planning participant groups or evidence sources.

> Create a stakeholder map for [problem] in [context]. Classify stakeholders by influence, exposure to the problem, knowledge, decision rights and possible bias. Flag any missing or marginalised perspectives.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Decide who can ethically and feasibly be included.

06 Consequence chain

Use when: Demonstrating why the problem matters.

> Construct a consequence chain from [problem] to operational, financial, human, customer, strategic and societal outcomes. Mark direct effects, plausible indirect effects and unsupported assumptions separately.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Validate consequences with real organisational or published evidence.

07 Boundary setter

Use when: The proposed study is too large.

> Help me bound [problem] by geography, organisation type, function, population, time period, process stage and outcome. Generate three scope options: narrow, balanced and broad, with feasibility risks.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Select the boundary that matches access and doctoral expectations.

08 Problem significance critique

Use when: Testing whether the problem deserves a doctorate.

> Critique the practical and scholarly significance of [problem]. Identify who would care, which decisions could change, and what would remain unchanged even if the study succeeds.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Decide whether the contribution justifies the effort.

09 Context transfer test

Use when: Contextualising established knowledge.

> A finding from [known context] is often assumed to apply to [my context]. Identify reasons the transfer may fail, including culture, regulation, technology, scale, capability and stakeholder incentives.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Verify whether literature actually supports the claimed transfer.

10 Research opportunity statement

Use when: Preparing an early concept note.

> Using only the information I provide, draft a 150-word research opportunity statement containing context, recurring problem, uncertainty, stakeholders, significance and boundary. List missing information after the draft.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Rewrite in your own accountable voice and substantiate claims.

B

Research Questions

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

11 Generate DBA-level options

Use when: Exploring alternative directions.

I work in [context] and observe [problem]. Generate five DBA-level research questions. For each, identify central concepts or variables, stakeholders, practical significance, scope, and a suitable broad approach. Do not invent evidence or citations.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Select based on purpose, access, literature and feasibility.

12 Question quality audit

Use when: A draft question exists.

Evaluate this question for clarity, neutrality, scope, feasibility, researchability, practical relevance and scholarly relevance: [question]. Score each criterion from 1 to 5, explain weaknesses and provide three revisions.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Accept only revisions that retain the real problem.

13 Remove embedded assumptions

Use when: The question sounds leading.

Identify every assumption embedded in this research question: [question]. Rewrite it so the conclusion is not predetermined and causal language is used only when justified.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Decide whether causality is conceptually and methodologically defensible.

14 Qualitative alternatives

Use when: Considering qualitative inquiry.

Create four qualitative research questions for [problem] focused respectively on experience, process, meaning and mechanism. Explain what each would reveal and what it would not reveal.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Choose based on the knowledge needed, not convenience.

15 Quantitative alternatives

Use when: Considering quantitative inquiry.

Create four quantitative research questions for [problem]: descriptive, correlational, predictive and causal. State the data and assumptions each would require.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Confirm data quality and whether causal inference is realistic.

16 Mixed-method integration

Use when: The problem needs breadth and depth.

> Propose three mixed-method research-question structures for [problem]. For each, explain the qualitative role, quantitative role and where integration occurs.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Ensure integration is necessary, not decorative.

17 Question-to-objective alignment

Use when: Building a proposal structure.

> Convert [research question] into one overall aim and four specific objectives using measurable research verbs. Then test whether each objective contributes directly to the question.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Revise objectives to match institutional conventions.

18 Sub-question architecture

Use when: The main question is too complex for one line of evidence.

> Develop three to five sub-questions that logically unpack [main question] without duplicating it. Map each sub-question to a possible evidence source.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Remove sub-questions that exceed scope.

19 Contribution test

Use when: Clarifying expected contribution.

> For [question], distinguish possible theoretical, empirical, methodological and practical contributions. Explain which claims would be excessive at proposal stage.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Do not promise contributions before evidence exists.

20 Viva challenge

Use when: Stress-testing a question.

> Act as a sceptical doctoral examiner. Ask ten difficult questions about the importance, scope, assumptions, feasibility and contribution of this research question: [question]. Do not answer them.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Prepare evidence-based answers yourself.

C

Literature Discovery

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

21 Concept blocks

Use when: Preparing a database search.

Create search-concept blocks for [topic] under phenomenon, context, population, mechanism/intervention and outcome. Provide synonyms, spelling variants, acronyms and adjacent disciplinary terms. Do not generate references.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Remove irrelevant terms and adapt to the database syntax.

22 Boolean strings

Use when: Moving from terms to search strings.

Using these concept blocks [paste], generate three Boolean search strings: broad discovery, balanced review and narrow precision. Explain the trade-off between recall and precision.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Test and document actual search results.

23 Database adaptation

Use when: Searching across databases.

Adapt this search string [string] for Google Scholar, Scopus and Web of Science. Explain phrase searching, field searching, wildcard and proximity differences without inventing database functions. Flag syntax that requires checking.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Confirm syntax in current official help pages.

24 Inclusion and exclusion criteria

Use when: Planning transparent screening.

Draft preliminary inclusion and exclusion criteria for a review on [question], covering topic relevance, context, population, evidence type, publication type, language and date. Identify criteria that may introduce bias.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Align criteria with the review purpose and supervisor guidance.

25 Seed-paper expansion

Use when: Using ResearchRabbit or Connected Papers.

Given this verified seed paper metadata [paste], propose a citation-network exploration plan: references, citing papers, similar papers, key authors and review articles. Do not claim that any paper exists beyond the provided metadata.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Inspect original records and avoid treating network centrality as quality.

26 Theme prediction

Use when: Organising an initial corpus.

> Based only on these article titles and abstracts [paste], propose tentative thematic clusters and explain why each article may fit. Mark uncertain classifications.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Read full texts before final coding.

27 Gap language auditor

Use when: Avoiding “no studies exist” overclaims.

> Review this claimed literature gap [text]. Identify whether it is an absence gap, contradiction, context gap, methodological gap, implementation gap or merely a weak search. Suggest evidence needed to support the claim.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Run a defensible search before claiming a gap.

28 Search log designer

Use when: Making the search traceable.

> Create a search-log template for [review purpose] with database, date, exact string, filters, result count, duplicates, screening decisions and notes.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Record real searches immediately and consistently.

29 Coverage check

Use when: Avoiding a narrow review.

> Given my current themes [list] and research question [question], identify likely missing perspectives, disciplines, stakeholder groups and counter-arguments to search for.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Decide whether additions are relevant or scope creep.

30 Citation verification protocol

Use when: Preventing fabricated or corrupted references.

> Create a step-by-step protocol to verify a citation suggested by AI using DOI, title, author, year, journal, database record and original full text. Include what to do when metadata conflicts.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Never cite until the original item is located and checked.

D

Reading & Synthesis

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

31 Structured paper extraction

Use when: Building an evidence table.

Using only the paper text I provide, extract purpose, context, theory, method, sample, measures, findings, limitations and contribution. Quote page or section locations when available. State “not reported” rather than infer.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Check every extraction against the paper.

32 Claim-evidence map

Use when: Reading critically.

From this provided paper excerpt [paste], map each major claim to its supporting evidence, method and limitation. Identify claims that exceed the evidence.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Read the surrounding context and full method.

33 Compare studies

Use when: Synthesising multiple studies.

Compare these verified study summaries [paste] across context, theory, method, sample, findings and limitations. Explain whether differences are contradictory or may arise from design and context.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Return to original papers before final interpretation.

34 Contradiction analysis

Use when: Interpreting inconsistent findings.

Two studies appear to disagree: [summaries]. Generate plausible explanations involving definitions, measurement, sample, context, time, method and analytical choices.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Do not decide without examining original designs.

35 Literature paragraph planner

Use when: Planning synthesis rather than serial summaries.

Create an argument outline for a literature-review paragraph using these verified evidence notes [paste]. Include topic sentence, synthesis, contrast, limitation and link to my study. Do not write citations or final prose.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Write the final paragraph in your own voice.

36 Theory comparison

Use when: Choosing a conceptual lens.

Compare [theory A] and [theory B] for explaining [phenomenon] in [context]. Cover assumptions, constructs, explanatory strengths, blind spots and implications for data collection. Flag where source verification is needed.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Read foundational and current theory sources.

37 Evidence matrix gaps

Use when: Diagnosing corpus limitations.

Review this evidence matrix [paste]. Identify empty cells, over-represented contexts, methodological concentration and unanswered stakeholder questions.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Decide whether gaps matter for your question.

38 Synthesis self-critique

Use when: Revising a review chapter.

Critique my literature synthesis [paste] for description without analysis, unsupported gap claims, cherry-picking, citation stacking, weak transitions and lack of conceptual integration.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Verify the critique and preserve justified nuance.

E

Framework & Method

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

39 Conceptual framework options

Use when: Visualising possible explanations.

> For [question], propose three alternative conceptual-framework structures using only concepts I provide [list]. Explain assumptions, possible relationships and what evidence would be required. Do not add theories or causal arrows without labelling them as proposals.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Select relationships only after literature review.

40 Methodology comparison

Use when: Early method choice.

> Compare qualitative, quantitative and mixed-method approaches for [question] across knowledge produced, sampling, data needs, analysis, validity, ethics, feasibility and limitations.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Choose based on the question, not familiarity.

41 Qualitative design selector

Use when: Considering qualitative design.

> Compare case study, phenomenology, grounded theory, ethnography and narrative inquiry for [problem]. State which research purpose each fits and common misuse risks.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Consult authoritative methodology sources and institutional expectations.

42 Sampling critique

Use when: Refining a sampling plan.

> Critique this proposed sampling plan [paste] for alignment, access, diversity, power, bias, saturation or sample-size justification. Ask clarification questions before recommending changes.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Make final decisions with methodological guidance and ethics review.

43 Interview guide generator

Use when: Preparing a draft instrument.

> Create a semi-structured interview guide for [question] with opening, experience, process, critical incident, contrast, consequence and closing questions. Avoid leading language and map each question to an objective.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Pilot, revise and obtain required approval.

44 Survey construct audit

Use when: Reviewing a draft survey.

Review these proposed survey constructs and items [paste]. Identify double-barrelled wording, leading questions, ambiguity, overlap and unsupported constructs. Do not claim validity.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Use validated measures where appropriate and test reliability/validity.

45 Mixed-method integration matrix

Use when: Designing mixed methods.

Create an integration matrix for [question] showing sequence, priority, connection, building, merging and joint-display opportunities. Explain why integration adds value.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Ensure workload and expertise are realistic.

46 Ethics risk scan

Use when: Preparing ethics documentation.

Identify potential consent, confidentiality, power, data-security, vulnerable-participant, conflict-of-interest and organisational-access risks in this proposed study [paste]. Do not replace formal ethics review.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Follow institutional ethics procedures and local law.

47 Feasibility stress test

Use when: Before committing to a design.

Stress-test this research design [paste] against time, access, response rate, data quality, software, skills, cost, approvals and contingency planning. Rank risks by probability and impact.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Create a realistic mitigation plan.

48 Method defence rehearsal

Use when: Preparing for proposal defence.

Act as a doctoral examiner and ask twelve questions challenging the alignment between my question, philosophy, design, sampling, instruments, analysis and claims.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Answer from methodological sources and your design logic.

F

Data & Analysis

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

49 Data dictionary

Use when: Preparing quantitative data.

Given these variable names and descriptions [paste], create a draft data dictionary with type, unit, coding, missing-value rule, valid range and source. Flag ambiguities rather than inventing definitions.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Validate against source systems and research protocol.

50 Cleaning plan

Use when: Before analysis.

Create a reproducible data-cleaning checklist for [dataset description], covering duplicates, missingness, invalid values, outliers, transformations and audit trail. Do not alter data.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Approve every rule and preserve raw data.

51 Analysis alignment

Use when: Planning analysis.

Map each research question and hypothesis to required variables, descriptive analysis, inferential or predictive method, assumptions and output. Flag where the method cannot answer the question.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Confirm with statistical expertise and data reality.

52 Code generation with tests

Use when: Obtaining a code scaffold.

Generate [Python/R] code for [analysis] using a simulated example structure, not my confidential data. Include comments, assumption checks, error handling and simple tests. Explain every analytical choice.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Run, inspect, validate and document all results.

53 Statistical output interpreter

Use when: Learning to interpret output.

Explain this statistical output [paste] in plain language, separating result, uncertainty, assumption, effect size and practical meaning. Do not claim causality unless the design supports it.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Check against software documentation and statistical guidance.

54 Qualitative coding assistant

Use when: Supporting early coding practice.

> Using only these de-identified excerpts [paste], propose tentative descriptive codes, code definitions and alternative interpretations. Preserve negative cases and mark uncertainty.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: The researcher owns the codebook and interpretation.

55 Theme quality check

Use when: Refining qualitative themes.

> Evaluate these proposed themes [paste] for internal coherence, distinctiveness, evidence coverage, hierarchy, negative cases and alignment with the question.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Return to raw data and reflexive notes.

56 Joint display planner

Use when: Mixed-method interpretation.

> Create a joint-display template integrating these quantitative results and qualitative themes [paste]. Include convergence, complementarity, contradiction and unanswered questions.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Make the meta-inferences yourself and retain contradictions.

G

Writing & Argument

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

57 Argument outline

Use when: Structuring before writing.

Create a logical argument outline for [chapter/section] based only on these verified claims and sources [paste]. Include claim, evidence, warrant, counterargument and transition.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Write final prose and check source fidelity.

58 Paragraph diagnostic

Use when: Improving academic writing without outsourcing it.

Diagnose this paragraph [paste] for one controlling idea, evidence integration, analytical depth, logical flow and unsupported claims. Suggest a revision plan, not a replacement paragraph.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Revise in your own voice.

59 Criticality upgrade

Use when: Developing critical writing.

Identify where this passage merely describes literature. Suggest questions that would add comparison, evaluation, contextualisation, contradiction and limitation.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Use only critiques supported by the literature.

60 Claim strength calibrator

Use when: Preventing overclaiming.

Classify each claim in this passage as descriptive, associative, predictive, causal, interpretive or normative. Flag claims stronger than the design or evidence permits.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Reword claims to match evidence and method.

61 Counterargument builder

Use when: Strengthening an argument.

Generate the strongest plausible counterarguments to this claim [claim] using the evidence notes I provide [paste]. State what additional evidence would resolve each issue.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Represent opposing evidence fairly.

62 Executive implication translator

Use when: Writing DBA recommendations.

> Translate these verified findings [paste] into implications for leaders, policy, process and capability. Separate direct evidence, reasonable inference and speculative recommendation.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Ensure recommendations respect context and study limitations.

63 Consistency audit

Use when: Final revision.

> Audit this chapter [paste] for consistency of terminology, research question, objectives, constructs, tense, claims and cross-references. Return a correction list.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Apply changes selectively; do not erase conceptual nuance.

64 Plain-language abstract

Use when: Communicating to professional audiences.

> Create a plain-language explanation of my study from this author-written abstract [paste]. Preserve uncertainty and avoid adding claims.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Verify that simplification has not changed meaning.

H

Integrity & Viva

Copy, contextualise, verify and take responsibility.

65 AI use disclosure draft

Use when: Preparing an AI-use statement.

Using this AI-use log [paste], draft a transparent disclosure stating tool names, purposes, stages, verification and human responsibility. Do not claim compliance with any institution or journal.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Adapt to the exact policy of the institution or publisher.

66 Citation hallucination audit

Use when: Prioritising manual checking.

Review this list of references [paste] for metadata inconsistencies, impossible dates, malformed DOI patterns, journal-title anomalies and duplicates. Do not confirm existence; produce a verification queue.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Locate every item in a legitimate source.

67 Confidentiality red-team

Use when: Before uploading research materials.

Review this proposed AI workflow [paste] and identify where confidential, personal, copyrighted or privileged information could be exposed. Suggest safer alternatives such as synthetic examples or approved environments.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Follow data-protection policy and ethics approval.

68 Bias challenge

Use when: Reflexive review.

Identify plausible biases in this research problem, sampling, instrument, analysis and AI-assisted workflow [paste]. Include researcher positionality and missing stakeholder perspectives.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Document genuine mitigation and limitations.

69 Viva simulation

Use when: Rehearsing a defence.

Conduct a viva simulation on this study summary [paste]. Ask one question at a time across originality, literature, method, findings, limitations, contribution and ethics. Challenge vague answers and request evidence.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Answer without outsourcing your reasoning.

70 Five-minute research pitch

Use when: Preparing a concise presentation.

> Using my verified study summary [paste], create a five-minute presentation structure with problem, evidence gap, question, method, finding/contribution and impact. Provide slide headings and timing, not a fabricated script.

HUMAN DECISION GATE: Build the final story and wording yourself.

QUICK REFERENCE

The Verification Footer

Add this line to any source-dependent prompt.

COPY THIS Distinguish clearly between information grounded in material I provided, general background knowledge, inference, assumption and uncertainty. Do not invent citations, quotations, statistics, organisations, datasets or findings. Give me a verification checklist for every source-dependent claim.

Standard Researcher Safety Footer

Do not process personal, confidential, privileged, unpublished or commercially sensitive data. Use placeholders or synthetic examples unless the system is explicitly approved for the data and the research protocol permits it. The researcher remains responsible for accuracy, originality, interpretation, citation and disclosure.